

IF THE MEN IN BLUE ENDED A LONG DROUGHT BY LIFTING THE T20 WORLD CUP IN 2024 (LEFT), THE WOMEN WENT ONE BETTER AND BECAME THE ODI CHAMPS IN 2025

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❝In 2017, Virat emerged as the Samrat of modern-day cricket and the new God to India's screaming millions. It was not just Virat's prodigious batting prowess (2,818 international runs in a calendar year, including six Test centuries, two of them back-to-back double centuries, apart from six centuries in the one-day format) or his feats as captain (nine back-to-back series wins as captain) or even his sparkling off-the-field life including his much celebrated marriage with actor Anushka Sharma recently. More than anything else, Virat transformed the Indian cricket team, making it an ultra-fit, fighting machine in his own mould. He wowed us with the intensity with which he plays the game, mesmerised us with his stroke play and he made us proud of his belief that nothing short of a win matters.❞

Then, under the long shadow of COVID-19, a battered, stitched-together XI of youngsters—Rishabh Pant, Shubman Gill, Mohammad Siraj et al—was thrust into the 2020–21 Border-Gavaskar Trophy. Their win, coming on the heels of India's first-ever Test series victory in Australia in 2018–19, brought the mojo back. The bench, suddenly, was a second frontline.

Near-misses persisted: World Test Championship final defeats in 2021 and 2023, and the devastating final loss in the 2023 WC. Yet by late 2023, India briefly sat No. 1 across formats, a reflection of structural change. The IPL had matured into a finishing school, the kind that polished Jasprit Bumrah into a generational force. Even late bloomers like Suryakumar Yadav, whose boundary-edge pirouette in the 2024 T20 World Cup final sealed India's long-awaited global title, were products of a democratic ecosystem.

But its most profound expression came from the women's game. Smriti Mandhana's serenity, Harmanpreet Kaur's defiance, Deepti Sharma's all-round command and a surge of young talent coalesced into a side that played not with hope but expectation. The culmination came in November 2025, when India lifted the Women's ODI World Cup—the crowning moment of a decade of Indian cricketing highs. ■